



YOU CAN TALK TO HIM WHENEVER YOU WANT. JUST CLOSE YOUR EYES AND CALL HIM

THE SPIRIT OF THE BEEHIVE / 1973

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Historical drama

DIRECTOR

Victor Erice

WRITERS

**Victor Erice, Ángel
Fernández Santos,
Francisco J. Querejeta**

STARS

**Fernando Fernán Gómez,
Teresa Gimpera, Ana
Torrent, Isabel Tellería**

BEFORE

1961 In British movie *Whistle Down the Wind*, a little girl finds a fugitive in a barn and believes he is Jesus.

AFTER

1976 In Carlos Saura's *Cría Cuervos* (*Raise Ravens*), Ana Torrent again plays a little girl haunted by visions.

1983 Erice's second movie, *The South* (*El Sur*), is about a girl fascinated by the secrets her father left in southern Spain.

Even though he was going blind, cinematographer Luis Cuadrado shot every frame of *The Spirit of the Beehive* (*El espíritu de la colmena*) in honey-colored sun and earth tones, rich in texture and deep, soft hues. Yet the movie's true beauty lies in the way director Victor Erice immerses us in the imagination of a six-year-old child, unforgettably played by the wide-eyed Ana Torrent.

The movie is set in 1940, the year after the Spanish Civil War ended in victory for Franco's Nationalists. It was a violent period of bloody retribution, about which it was still not possible to talk openly in Spain, even in 1973. General Franco was still in power, and censors strove to curtail any criticism of the regime. Erice's movie not only depicted a controversial era, but also contained coded messages about the state of the nation. Yet the movie made it past the censors, possibly because

it is so slow-moving and enigmatic that the censors believed it would never find an audience.

Finding the monster

The movie opens with the arrival of a traveling cinema in a village. The movie playing is James Whale's 1931 monster flick *Frankenstein*. The child Ana is thrilled by the monster, but baffled by the scene in which he appears to drown the little girl—thanks to a misleading cut made by Spanish censors, who were showing the movie as propaganda that equated the monster with socialism.

Ana (Ana Torrent)

offers an apple to the fugitive she finds hidden in the family outhouse. She believes he is the monster.

